

Theoretically, Pemberton could still contest the crossing, so Grant ordered a diversion. Brigadier General Benjamin Grierson, in command of a Union cavalry brigade, was sent south, deep into Mississippi, to destroy the railroads supplying Vicksburg, confuse Pemberton, and keep the Confederates off balance. The raiders rode southward to the east of Jackson, eventually swinging west to join up with Union troops at Baton Rouge, Louisiana. The ruse worked.

Pemberton sent most of his cavalry and an entire division on a wild goose chase after the elusive Grierson, while Grant ferried his army to the Mississippi shore of the river. Sherman's corps also covered this operation, threatening a new advance on Chickasaw Bluffs. Grant's force moved swiftly inland, cut off from their supply lines, and lived off the enemy's land. He defeated a small Confederate garrison at Port Gibson on May 1, then marched northeast toward the state capital at Jackson.

To effect his assault on Vicksburg, Grant had 70 miles (113km) of corduroy road (made from tree trunks laid across the route) built between his base and the river crossing-point at Hard Times.